6

Rethinking Evangelism

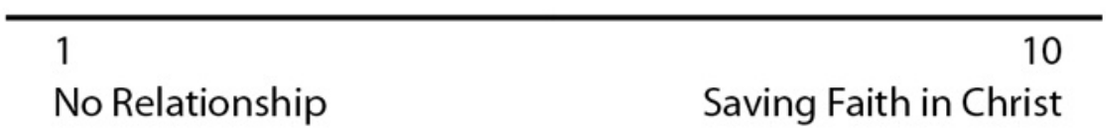
> Insanity: doing the same thing over and over again and expecting different results.
>
> Albert Einstein

At this point in the journey, I am hopeful it is abundantly clear that approaches to evangelism used in the past must be ruthlessly reevaluated in light of the nature of a post-Christian culture and the generation it has spawned. The most foundational rethinking is one that in previous writings and in multiple settings I've sketched out to try to persuade pastors and church leaders of one foundational dynamic: the importance of process.

And I would like to sketch this out again here (see fig. 6.1).[1]

Let's set up a line with a scale from 1 to 10. We will set as a "1" any individual without knowledge of, or relationship with, Christ. And at a "10" is any individual who has made the decision to cross the line of faith and enter into a relationship with Christ.

Figure 6.1



Using this scale, I want to look at these individuals, and culture as a whole, and contrast the year 1960 with what we find today. In thinking about the unchurched person living in the United States in 1960, I believe that I could reasonably argue that these beliefs would have been typical for them:

- an acceptance of the deity of Christ
- a belief that truth exists and that the Bible is trustworthy
- a positive image of the church and its leaders
- a church background and experience that were relatively healthy
- a foundational knowledge of the essential truths of the Christian faith
- a built-in sense of guilt or conviction that kicked in when they violated the basic tenets of the Judeo-Christian value system

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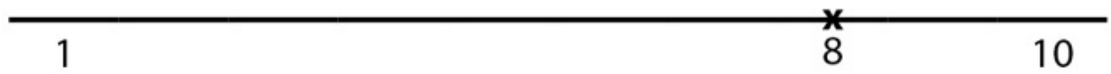
Given all of this, I would place this person at an “8” in terms of their readiness to engage with and respond to the gospel (see fig. 6.2).

Figure 6.2

1960



All it would take to move them from an 8 to a 10 (crossing the line of faith) was a bump. This made the evangelistic strategies of the 1960s—door-to-door visitation, Sunday school, church revivals and busing—extremely successful for the day. Evangelism was very “event” oriented, and the presentation of the Gospel and the message of salvation were often all it took for someone to cross the line of faith. I’ve often joked that if I were to meet a non-Christian like this I could get them to Jesus with a tweet!

If it has not already, the church needs to quickly come to the realization that strategies like these are no longer effective, because today so many people in our post-Christian culture are not just simply unchurched but solidly in the none category. Or they are a part of the squishy center discussed earlier that is moving decidedly to the left. And if they are a part of Generation Z, they are further removed from even a memory of the gospel. Today, the typical unchurched person on our scale would most likely fall at a “3” (see fig. 6.3).

Figure 6.3

Today

The church must rethink evangelism—no longer can we be simply event driven. The church must view evangelism as both a process *and* an event. Because we are not dealing with an unchurched culture resting at an 8 (with a relatively advanced spiritual knowledge) but instead with a post-Christian unchurched culture resting at a 3, we must pay fresh attention to the *process* that leads people *to* the event of salvation. The goal is not simply knowing how to articulate the means of coming to Christ (when they move to a 10) but knowing how to facilitate and enable the person to progress up our scale from a 3 to a 7 or an 8, where they are able to even consider accepting Christ in a meaningful way.

Echoing this sentiment, in a rather obscure essay on modern man and his categories of thought, C. S. Lewis argued that when the gospel first broke out, the evangelistic task was essentially to one of three groups: Jews, Judaizing Gentiles, or pagans. All three believed in the supernatural. All were conscious of sin and feared divine judgment. Each offered some form of personal purification and release. They all believed the world had once been better than it now was. But now, Lewis argued, the average person shares none of those marks. In fact, he ended the essay by stating, “I sometimes wonder whether we shall not have to re-convert men to real Paganism as a preliminary to converting them to Christianity.”[2]

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Acts 2 versus Acts 17

So what does this situation mean practically? The heart of any evangelistic process is going to have to major in explanation. *Everything* must be explained, from music to messages, symbols to ritual, because so little is understood.

Let me suggest a biblical paradigm I have attempted to convey throughout my writings in recent years in relation to this rethinking. Biblically, it is as if we have moved from an Acts 2 cultural context to an Acts 17 cultural context.

In Acts 2, Peter is before the God-fearing Jews of Jerusalem. Here, in essence, was his message: "You know about the creation, Adam and Eve, and the fall; you know about Abraham and the chosen people of Israel; you know about Moses and the law; you know about the prophets and the promised coming of the Messiah. So we don't need to waste time on all that. What you need to know is that Jesus was that Messiah, you rejected him and killed him, and he rose again and unleashed his church, which means you need to repent."

It wasn't even the length of a good blog.

Result? Three thousand repented! Peter was able to speak to a group of people who were already monotheists, who already bought into the Old Testament Scriptures, and who already believed in a coming Messiah.

Now move forward to Acts 17, featuring Paul on Mars Hill speaking to the philosophers and spiritual seekers of Athens. Here was a spiritual marketplace where truth was relative, worldviews and gods littered the landscape, and the average person wouldn't know the difference between Isaac and an iPad. Paul knew he wasn't in Jerusalem anymore. So he didn't take an Acts 2 approach, much less give an Acts 2 message. He had to find a new way to connect with the culture and the people in it.

Paul surveyed the cultural landscape and found a touchstone—an altar to an unknown God. The culture was so pluralistic that the only thing people could agree on was that you couldn't know anything for sure. "What if I could tell you that God's name? Would that be of interest?" Paul began. He then went all the way back to creation and began to work his way forward—laying a foundation for an understanding and acceptance of the gospel.

Different culture, different approach.

This is precisely where we find ourselves today. We are not speaking to the God-fearing Jews in Jerusalem. We are standing on Mars Hill and need an Acts 17 mindset with an Acts 17 strategy. Which means our primary cultural currency is going to need to be explanation. It's not enough to move from a King James Version of the Bible to Eugene Peterson's uber-contemporary paraphrase *The Message* in our speaking. We have to begin by saying, "This is a Bible. It has sixty-six books. There's an Old Testament and a New Testament. It tells the story of us and God."

And then we need to explain that story.

This was driven home to me through the 2013 movie *Gravity* about an astronaut, played by George Clooney, and a medical engineer, played by Sandra Bullock, who work together in an effort to survive after a catastrophe destroys their shuttle and leaves them adrift in orbit. It was a critically acclaimed, special-effects spectacular.

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But I was taken by one scene in particular, a moment when the character played by Bullock felt she was going to die. Her character, Ryan Stone, speaks the following words through her tears to the emptiness of space:

> Oh, I'm going to die . . . I know . . . we're all gonna die, everybody knows that. But I'm going to die today! It's funny that . . . you know, to know. But the thing is, is that I'm still scared. I'm really scared. No one will mourn for me, no one will pray for my soul. Will you mourn for me? Will you say a prayer for me? Or is it too late?
>
> Ugh. I mean, I'd say one for myself, but I've never prayed in my life, so. . .
>
> But nobody ever taught me how. Nobody ever taught me how.[3]

That scene has haunted me ever since I first saw it. No one ever taught her to pray. No one explained it.

But someone could have.

The Curse of Knowledge

So why don't people explain? Much of the problem rests with what has been called the curse of knowledge.

Try something. Tap out the beats to "Happy Birthday" with your hand on a desk or chair or whatever is handy where you are reading this. You're singing the song in your head while tapping out the beats with your hand or fingers. It takes only a few seconds.

Okay, once you do it, ask yourself, "Do I think most people would guess the song based on my beats?" It's such a familiar song that, if you're like most people, you probably imagine they would have.

This was an actual experiment conducted at Stanford University. Researchers found that listeners were able to guess a song right only about 2.5 percent of the time—getting three songs out of about one hundred twenty. But here's what's interesting. The person tapping thought those listening were getting it right at least 90 percent of the time. So the listeners were getting the song right only one time out of forty, but the tapper thought they were getting it right one time out of every two.

The difference was that the tapper was hearing the song in their head. When they were tapping, they couldn't imagine the other person not hearing the song in the background. This is called the curse of knowledge. Once we know something, we find it hard to imagine what it's like not to know it.[4]

Have you forgotten what it's like to be apart from Christ?

The world needs you to remember.

We're so used to talking to the already convinced that we have lost our intuitive sense of what it means to talk to someone who isn't a Christ follower. I assume no knowledge whatsoever. I never use terms such as *Trinity*, *revelation*, *sin*, or *grace* without explaining what they mean. Even something as elemental as how I reference a passage in the Bible is explanatory in nature. Instead of saying, "This passage is from John 1:14," I say something along the lines of, "This is from the biography of Jesus written by John, one of our four biographies in the Bible."

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As much as I consider myself sensitized to this as the pastor of a church with over 70 percent of its growth from the unchurched, I still get startling reminders that keep me on my toes, such as this response from a woman following an email about an upcoming celebration of the Lord's Supper:

> Thanks for the informative email. I have been going to Meck for about a month now and I love it! I have even talked my two friends into joining. We are all thankful to be part of an awesome church with great values. I do have one question. I remember hearing about . . . [an upcoming] celebration of the Lord's Supper. What does that mean? . . . What is a celebration of the Lord's Supper? Does that mean we all bring some kind of food to share? I am planning on going . . . but I wanted to make sure I bring something if need be. Any information you can provide . . . would be greatly appreciated!

Such illiteracy is not confined to biblical knowledge; it involves the dynamics of spiritual life itself. I have to show how a life that follows Christ is actually marked by that following. This means I have to apply the Bible's teaching to life's most pressing challenges, conflicts, and choices. The goal is to illustrate what a Christ follower would do or think, and how it is always the better road. This is why, besides the life and teaching of Jesus, one of the most important books of the New Testament to teach regularly is the book of James. It's the primer on how to live differently as a spiritual person.

And as I explain the gospel, the most important tightrope I walk is explaining the grace-truth dynamic within the gospel itself. This is so important to get right. Not only is it the heart of the gospel, but it is also at the heart of many of the most regrettable caricatures and stereotypes abounding about Christians and Christianity in our world today. At the most basic level, the goal is to hold both grace and truth together. Truth without grace is just judgment. Grace without truth is license. Only authentic Christianity brings together both truth and grace. Which isn't surprising, considering that this is precisely what Jesus brought when he came.

In John's Gospel, a theological bombshell was offered almost as an offhand comment: Jesus "came . . . full of grace and truth" (John 1:14). Jesus accepted the woman at the well despite her culturally scandalous ways, but he followed the acceptance by challenging her directly about her serial promiscuity. He stopped the stoning of a woman caught in adultery and made it clear he was not going to condemn her, but then he pointedly admonished her to turn from her adulterous ways. Grace *and* truth, as they flowed from Jesus, were inextricably intertwined. They also flowed from him in a way that was winsome. The very people he challenged about the state of their lives wanted him to come to their parties and meet their friends . . . and then challenge them! Jesus offered neither a feel-good theology that airbrushed out any real talk of sin nor legalistic attitudes of harsh condemnation and judgment. He came bringing grace and truth at their best and most compelling.

Most of us swing in one direction or another, either toward grace without truth or toward truth without grace. We either side with the woman caught in adultery and trumpet, "Neither do I condemn you," or we side with those who want to highlight "go and sin no more." Today, as previously discussed, I sense most are trending toward grace without truth. It's as if we are so ashamed of the judgmental, condemnatory nature of the church's recent history that we've swung as far in the other direction as we can. While understandable, the reality is that lukewarm religion holds little value in the midst of a settling secularism. What grips a conscience is anything *gripping*. If a worldview or faith lacks conviction, passion, or life change, then it is presenting itself as both privately and socially irrelevant. This means that the

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only kind of voice that will arrest the attention of the world will be convictional in nature, clear in its message, substantive in its content, and bold in its challenge. Translation: grace and truth in equal measure.

But explanation isn't the only rethinking at hand when it comes to evangelism. The second is to be quick about it.

Eight-Second Filters

What has been conventional wisdom is true: attention spans have been shrinking dramatically in recent years—more dramatically than most have realized. According to the research of the National Center for Biotechnology Information, the average attention span has dropped from 12 seconds in 2000 to just 8.25 seconds in 2015. That's around a 25 percent drop in just over a decade. To put that into perspective, the average attention span of a goldfish is 9 seconds. No, I did not make that up. We're .75 seconds less attentive than Bubbles. So what does 8.25 seconds of attention mean in day-in, day-out life? Here are some facts:

- percent of teens who forget major details of close friends and relatives: 25
- percent of people who forget their own birthdays from time to time: 7
- average number of times per hour an office worker checks their email inbox: 30[5]

So what does this mean for a church trying to reach out to an internet-based generation? Here are some internet browsing statistics that may cause you to rethink everything:

- average length watched of a single internet video: 2.7 minutes
- percent of page views that last less than 4 seconds: 17
- percent of page views that last more than 10 minutes: 4
- percent of words read on web pages with 111 words or less: 49
- percent of words read on an average (593 words) web page: 28[6]

Bottom line? Whatever it is we are attempting to convey, much less explain, will need to be communicated more frequently in shorter bursts of "snackable content." Why? Because members of Generation Z are the "ultimate consumers of snack media. They communicate in bite sizes."[7]

Some have suggested that what is really operating are highly evolved eight-second filters. Members of Generation Z, for example, are growing up in a world in which options and information are virtually limitless; time, of course, is not. So they have developed, almost out of necessity, the ability to quickly sort through enormous amounts of data. Or they rely on sources that do that for them, such as trending information within apps. The good news is that once something *does* gain their attention and is deemed worthy of time, they can become intensely committed and focused. The very internet that forced them to develop eight-second filters is the same internet that allows them to go deep on any topic they desire and to learn

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from a community of fellow interested parties. This means we can still engage people on a very deep level with truth. The bad news? We have eight seconds to get past their filters.[8] As one eighteen-year-old UCLA student said, "Generation Z takes in information instantaneously and loses interest just as fast."[9]

The *Wall Street Journal* chronicled how such insights are necessarily shaping every area of life, including sports. The St. Louis Rams, for example, have one of the youngest teams in the NFL, with an average age of twenty-four. As coach Jeff Fisher put it, "Our players learn better with two phones and music going and with an iPad on the side. That's new."

So the Rams brought in a group of academics who run a research firm to evaluate their football teaching methods. They discovered that attention spans are shorter but that the players are savvier than ever because of their exposure to technology. So instead of having team meetings that last hours, followed by on-field practicing, "the team now has 10 to 15 minutes' worth of informational meetings and then hurries to the practice field to execute what they've just learned." Coaches also adjusted to the reality that most of their young players are visual learners who can best be reached by "a hundred different examples" of football scenarios. They also encourage their players to communicate with each other through apps such as Instagram and Snapchat.[10]

So rethinking evangelism involves (1) recapturing a sense of evangelism as both process and event, (2) having that process be heavily oriented toward explanation, and (3) having that explanation be conveyed in a quick and engaging manner in order to get past filters. That's why Dan Schawbel, managing partner of Millennial Branding, a New York consultancy, tells his advertising partners "that if they don't communicate in five words and a big picture, they will not reach this generation."[11] Which leads to an area that may need the most rethinking of all: that "big picture." In other words, the importance of being visual.

The Importance of the Visual

As I wrote in *The Rise of the Nones*, we have much we can learn from history about the importance of the visual.[12] The Lindisfarne Gospels is a thirteen-hundred-year-old manuscript revered to this day as the oldest surviving English version of the Gospels (see fig. 6.4). Lindisfarne, often referred to as Holy Island, is a small island just off the Northumberland coast of England that is unreachable for several hours every day because of the tidal waters flowing around it.

A man named Eadfrith produced the Lindisfarne Gospels—a copy of the four Gospels of the New Testament—around AD 715 in honor of St. Cuthbert. Its pages reveal curvy, embellished letters, strange creatures, and spiraling symbols of exquisite precision and beauty. During the eighth century, spiritual pilgrims flocked to St. Cuthbert's shrine to see the Lindisfarne Gospels, making it one of the most visited and seen books of its day. The artwork and symbols on its pages helped convey the message of the Gospel to those who could not read.

Designed to be a visual, sensual, and artistic experience for its audience, the Lindisfarne Gospels is seen as a precursor to modern multimedia, according to Professor Richard Gameson from Durham University. "The emphasis," he says, "was to reach as many people as

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possible."[13] There are many strategies needed for the church to have an open "front door"—to help those who are unchurched to come and feel not only welcomed but also connected. What we can learn from the Lindisfarne Gospels is that in order to reach the culture today, the church needs to be visual—in our methods and in our explanations.

Over the last twenty years, the world has become increasingly visually based, with video and film becoming the most formative influences on culture. As mentioned, at the time the Lindisfarne Gospels was produced there was widespread illiteracy. People went on spiritual pilgrimages not only for the experience of seeing the relics and holy places they hoped would bestow grace but also to see the beautiful stained glass built into the cathedrals that told the story of faith in a medium they could understand: *pictures*.

It's no different today.

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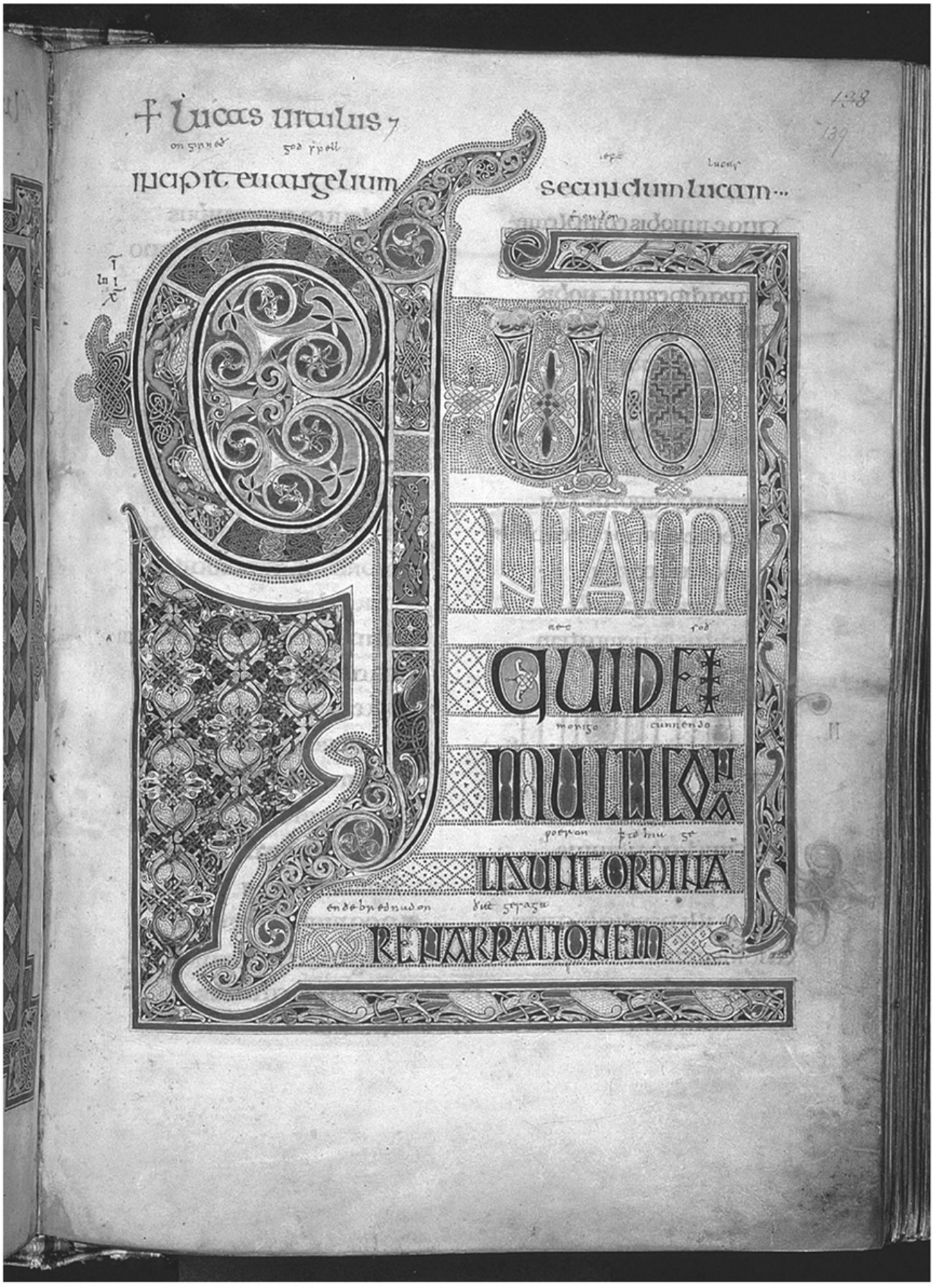
Figure 6.4

Lindisfarne Gospels



Lindisfarne Gospels, Wikimedia Commons

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Generation Z is not only spiritually illiterate, but very visually oriented and informed. They consume knowledge of the world through YouTube, Netflix, Hulu—anything they find visually gripping. So when we plan the weekend services at Meck—which, for now, continues to remain our primary "front door" experience—there is very little we don't try to convey visually, whether during a song that is a part of worship or a point being made in the sermon. For example, before singing a song with the word "hallelujah" in it, we would show an introductory video explaining what the word means. We try to convey the "story" across multiple screens in multiple forms. It's simply how people best receive information and meaning, content and context.

But the need for the visual goes beyond something as basic as video. It's reflected in the changing nature of language itself.

The "Word" of the Year

The depth of this shift to the visual was evidenced when *Oxford Dictionary* named its 2015 word of the year. Here's the word:

Yes, it is a pictograph or, as it is more commonly called, an emoji. It is the "Face with Tears of Joy" emoji. While emojis have been around since the late 1990s, "2015 saw their use, and use of the word *emoji*, increase hugely." This particular emoji was selected because it was identified as the most used emoji globally in 2015.

In case you are a closet Luddite, an emoji is "a small digital image or icon used to express an idea or emotion in electronic communication." The term itself is Japanese in origin "and comes from *e* 'picture' + *moji* 'letter, character.' The similarity to the English word emoticon has helped its memorability and rise in use." An emoticon, by the way, is a "facial expression composed of keyboard characters, such as :), rather than a stylized image."[14]

The use of emojis reflects the cultural revolution that has come with technology in general and the smartphone in particular. It's also the only form of language that can transcend linguistic borders, serving the interconnected world of the internet, which knows no geopolitical or language boundaries. But more than anything, the use of emojis reflects the changing nature of communication itself. And when it comes to reaching the latest and largest generation—Generation Z—emojis are part of their language. The research of Sparks and Honey found that members of Generation Z "speak in emoticons and emojis. Symbols and glyphs provide context and create subtext so they can have private conversations. Emoji alphabets and icon 'stickers' replace text with pictures."[15] This is why, during a recent slate of Christmas Eve services, we presented the entire Christmas story through a video of two people texting each other using emojis, emoticons, and gifs. In other words, the way people today increasingly communicate. What follows is the script of the video.

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Emoji Christmas Story

👩🎄🎁 Merry Christmas! 👩🎄🎁

You too! ❄️❄️❄️

I 😍🌲 !

I know! The 🎁🎁🎁!

The 🍰🍪🍰🍪!

👩!

🎇!!!

Wait . . . what's that?

A ☆ ! You know 🌲 the Christmas story 🌲

😳 ????

You know 🙏👼😇

Right! 👩

Not really . . . 😬

Oh. 😐 ✋ I can't tell you! 😃

👍👏

The full story is in the Bible 📖

Good to know 👍

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So, the Virgin Mary . . . 👰 . . . was told by an 😇 that she was expecting a 👶 . . .

😱😮😱

And that 👶 = JESUS!!!

😮

And 👰 was like 😳

Ya think?! 😱

👰 and her fiancé Joseph 👨 got married 👰💍💎💘

And 👰 rode on a 🐴 to Bethlehem with her husband Joseph . . .

👍 I like the mustache 😄😂

There was no 🏠 to stay in tho for 👰👨 . . .

So they were forced to stay where all the animals were kept 😷🐑🐮🐖🐓🐀

😟😕😐😳

Yeah it wasn't pretty. 😑😓

What happened next? 🙀

Well there were 🐑🐑🚶🚶 nearby . . .

What are those?? 😂

Shepherds! 😂👍

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Oh! 😅

An 😇 came to them and said:

"Fear not! I bring you great news and joy today. In the town of David a Savior has been born to you. He's the Messiah, the Lord. This will be a sign to you—you will find a baby wrapped in cloth and lying in a manger."

I bet the shepherds were like
😮😱😄😆😎😊👏

Yep! They 🏃 to see 👶

There were also wise men 👳🏿, who wished to 👀 a 👶
. . . So they followed a 🌟 that led to the 👶 . . . they brought
🎁💝🎁🎈🎉🎋

🎉🎉🎈🎈 HBD Jesus! 🎋

😀 It's awesome right?! And now we 🎉 on 🎄 to remember the 🎁 God gave us

And that 🎁 is . . . 👶 !!!!

👏👏👏 You got it!

See, I told my 👵 texting wasn't a waste of time!!

😂, I guess there's just 1 thing left to say . . . 🎼🎤 JOY TO THE WORLD!!!! 🎹🎷🎸👍

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Invitation Works

About this time, you may be wondering how you will even get a chance to employ strategies like these with someone from Generation Z. It's not like they are lining up to have a chat with you.

But they could.

According to the research of the Barna Group, the unchurched continue to be most open to "a friend of yours inviting you to attend a local church," with one-fifth expressing strong interest and nearly half willing to consider a church based on this factor. "It's the top-rated way churches can establish connections with the unchurched."[16] With Generation Z, this approach can be especially effective, with 28 percent placing emphasis on their personal relationships compared to Millennials at 20 percent.[17] We've discussed eight-second attention spans for those in Generation Z. But when it comes to responding to a text or direct message from a friend? The Gen Z response is "immediate."[18] The personal and the relational cut through the noise of their lives.

The Great Enabler

But lest we think in too traditional of ways, we must realize that evangelism is not going to be something that takes place only in the context of a weekend service, much less within the context of a personal relationship. Evangelism's most common context may be online. Now don't think that means simply going online for Jesus. We must understand, first and foremost, how the internet is shaping the nature of choice and belief by becoming what I've called the "Great Enabler."

Through a search engine like Google, you can find not only a community in support of whatever choice you would like to make but also a clear apologetic for making it—and, if needed, the people and steps needed to pursue it. You want to pursue a gay lifestyle in a country like Pakistan where it is illegal? As one Pakistani told a reporter, "One of the first things I did online, maybe twelve years ago, was type in G-A-Y and hit search. Back then I found a group and made contact with twelve people in this city." The same article, focused on Google and sex, found a similar phenomenon in Britain with the growth of the fetish scene. Veteran "kinksters" in the UK tell how the internet completely transformed the number of people involved. Translation: it vastly increased those involved in the fetish scene.

As the article opines:

> Before the dawn of the Internet, people who experienced this urge would probably bury their desires deep down, maybe try to slake their needs with hard-to-obtain and dubious mail-order catalogues, or with sex phone lines.
>
> Now, they are only one click from a webpage that will explain—and crucially, normalize—those desires. There's usually an FAQ page, with "Am I crazy?" near the top. The answer, by the way, is always "No," and it's always society that's in the wrong. . . .
>
> The Internet also allows browsers to delve deeper, find online communities and forums, and reinforce their beliefs among a group of people who, for the first time, won't challenge them or call them mad.

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> Sooner or later, whatever your bent, you can insulate yourself among like-minded people, until you think you're the normal one, and the rest of us are the intolerant.[19]

In a similar vein, the internet impacts faith. "Especially with young people . . . there's an openness with respect to choosing your religion, as opposed to just staying with the religion you're born into," says Christopher Smith, author of *Atheist Awakening*. "The Internet facilitates this: People who might otherwise feel isolated by the religious mores in their hometowns have access to communities of people who believe otherwise." This corresponds with the staggeringly high number of atheists who are, themselves, young. An estimated 42 percent of all atheists are between eighteen and twenty-nine years old.[20]

So evangelism will require not only fresh approaches to content but also new methods of communication. To stand on Mars Hill today will necessarily involve sitting behind a screen, entering into an insular world that many inhabit, all to attempt to offer a compelling alternative to the life they've been living. Members of Generation Z are "agile communicators: speed of communication and repartee garners cultural currency," note Sparks and Honey. "They're accustomed to rapid-fire banter and commentary."[21]

Give it to them.

Engage their questions, their viewpoints, and their perspectives. Enter into their chat rooms, respond to their blogs, answer their tweets. The news is filled with the success of ISIS in luring young people to their radicalized version of Islam through the internet. As the *New York Times* has detailed, "The reach of the Islamic State's recruiting effort has been multiplied by an enormous cadre of operators on social media. The terrorist group itself maintains a 24-hour online operation, and its effectiveness is vastly extended by larger rings of sympathetic volunteers and fans who pass on its messages and viewpoint, reeling in potential recruits."[22]

Christian evangelists need to take a page from the very same playbook, because it's the playbook for an entire generation.

A Theology of Evangelism

But we can't make evangelism simply about tactics. The heart of the problem with evangelizing any generation in a post-Christian world is Christians who don't feel they need evangelizing. Buried within Pew's study on the American religious landscape was a startling find. Adults who identify with a specific religion were asked whether they see their religion as "the one, true faith leading to eternal life" or if, in their view, "many religions can lead to eternal life." How we answer such a question will determine whether evangelism is integral or peripheral, a matter of urgency or complacency.

In a stunning revelation, among Christians, two-thirds said many religions can lead to eternal life, and most of them (50 percent of all Christians) said some non-Christian religions can lead to life everlasting.[23] With such a mindset in play, we should not be surprised at tepid attempts at evangelism. And when attempted, poor results.

Recently, the Church of England went so far as to signal to its members that it does more harm than good for them to speak openly about their faith when it comes to spreading Christianity. Internal research found that "practicing Christians who talk to friends and

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colleagues about their beliefs are three times as likely to put them off God as to attract them." Solution? Let's stop talking to them. This response despite the fact that the same survey found that four out of ten British adults did not even think Jesus was a "real person who actually lived." Among those under the age of thirty-five, one out of every four believed him to be a fictional character.[24]

So perhaps the key is learning how to talk about Jesus in a good way. An effective way. A bridge-building way. Which is, of course, the purpose and role of apologetics.

Discussion Questions

1. What does it mean to see evangelism as both process and event? How does that differ from past approaches?
2. If you're being honest, does your outreach strategy reflect an Acts 2 or an Acts 17 approach? Why do you say that?
3. What does it mean for our primary cultural currency in the church to be explanation when it comes to evangelism? How are you currently involving explanation in your evangelism strategy? How might you begin to do so?
4. Sometimes in the church we're so used to talking to the already convinced that we lose a sense of what it means to talk to someone who isn't. Based on what you've read so far, have you lost touch with the mindset of the average person today? Reflect on that, however painful it may be.
5. What makes the grace and truth balance so hard? How can your church improve the balance in your ministry?
6. Should your ministry change in light of the fact that people today have an average attention span of just over eight seconds? If so, how? If not, why not?
7. With the shaping of worldviews that happens so effectively through visual media, are there ways you can begin leveraging video, images, or other visual media to better translate the gospel to your audience?

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